30
TERMS

WORDS TO KNOW

30 Project Management Terms to Help You Navigate the Projects That Matter in Life

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Veteran Who Understands Transition

LIFE IS A JOURNEY · ENJOY THE RIDE

WELCOME

You know more than you think.

Look for yourself.

You may have been managing projects long before anyone gave you the title *Project Manager*.

Perhaps you moved your family across the country, returned to school, changed careers, bought a home, started a business, cared for someone you love, wrote a book, planned a wedding, rebuilt after a setback, or simply tried to figure out what comes next. Those are projects too.

Professional project managers have words for many of the things you already encounter in everyday life. Learning those words doesn't make life predictable. It gives you another way to recognize what is happening, make wiser decisions, and keep moving when the road changes.

You don't need to memorize these definitions. Just become familiar with them. Soon, you may discover that you already know more about managing projects than you thought.

Crystal

How to use this guide: each term has a short definition and a **Simply put** line that translates it into everyday life. Read it straight through, or keep it nearby and look up a word when it shows up in your week.

The Project

01 Project

A temporary effort undertaken to create a specific result. It has a beginning, an intended destination, and work required to get there.

SIMPLY PUT Something you are trying to accomplish that won't happen by itself.

02 Objective

The specific result the project is intended to accomplish.

SIMPLY PUT What are you trying to get done?

03 Scope

The boundaries of the project — the work that belongs and the work that doesn't.

SIMPLY PUT Know what belongs in your project before everything starts belonging in your project.

04 Scope Creep

Work that gets added without being properly considered or approved.

SIMPLY PUT “It's just one little thing” can become ten little things.

05 Requirement

Something the project or final result needs to provide, satisfy, or accomplish.

SIMPLY PUT What must this actually do?

06 Deliverable

A specific result, product, service, or other output the project is expected to produce.

SIMPLY PUT What are you actually producing?

07 Milestone

A significant point or achievement in the project.

SIMPLY PUT A marker that tells you, “We made it this far.”

08

Baseline

An approved point of reference used to compare what was planned with what is actually happening.

SIMPLY PUT You need something to compare against before you can tell what changed.

The People

09

Stakeholder

Anyone who can affect the project or is affected by it.

SIMPLY PUT Who cares about what you're doing, depends on it, influences it, or lives with the result?

10

Sponsor

The person who champions the project and can provide support, direction, resources, or higher-level decisions when needed.

SIMPLY PUT Who has the authority and influence to help the project move?

The Work

11

Backlog

An organized list of work that may need to be completed or considered.

SIMPLY PUT Everything important doesn't have to be done today. Give future work somewhere to live.

12

Priority

The relative importance or urgency of one item compared with another.

SIMPLY PUT What deserves your attention first?

13

Dependency

Something that relies on something else happening first or at the right time.

SIMPLY PUT What are you waiting on — and who might be waiting on you?

14

Impediment

Something preventing or slowing the team or project from moving forward.

SIMPLY PUT What's in the way? Recognizing it matters. Helping remove it matters more.

What Could Change

15

Risk

An uncertain event or condition that could affect the project positively or negatively.

SIMPLY PUT What might happen that could change the plan?

16

Issue

A problem or condition that is happening now and needs attention.

SIMPLY PUT A risk might happen. An issue already has.

17

Trigger

A warning sign or condition indicating that a risk may be getting closer.

SIMPLY PUT What's the road sign telling you to pay attention?

18

Assumption

Something believed to be true for planning purposes even though it hasn't been completely confirmed.

SIMPLY PUT What are you counting on being true?

19

Constraint

A limitation or restriction the project must work within.

SIMPLY PUT What can't you ignore — time, money, people, rules, or something else?

20

Variance

The difference between what you planned and what actually happened.

SIMPLY PUT Something changed. Now find out why.

When the Plan Changes

21

Change Control

A deliberate way of considering and managing significant changes instead of simply allowing them to happen.

SIMPLY PUT Don't change the plan without understanding what else the change may affect.

22

Impact Assessment

Looking at what a proposed change could affect before committing to it.

SIMPLY PUT If we change this, what else moves?

23

Rolling-Wave Planning

Planning near-term work in greater detail while leaving future work at a higher level until more is known.

SIMPLY PUT Plan what you know well enough to move forward. Add detail as you learn. The plan grows with the project.

24

Progressive Elaboration

Adding greater detail and understanding to work that was already part of the project as more information becomes available.

SIMPLY PUT The work isn't secretly growing. You're learning more about what was already there.

Finding What Is Really Happening

25

Cause-and-Effect Analysis

A way of looking beyond the visible problem to understand what may be causing it.

SIMPLY PUT Don't keep fixing the symptom. Find out why it keeps happening.

26

Pareto / 80-20

A way of focusing attention on the relatively small number of causes that may be creating most of the problem or result.

SIMPLY PUT Find the few things making the biggest difference.

27

Conformance

Whether the work meets the agreed requirements or specifications.

SIMPLY PUT Did we build what we said we would build? But there is another question worth asking: Does it actually work for the person who needs it? Something can meet every written requirement and still miss the real need.

How the Work Gets Done

28

Agile

An adaptive way of working that uses shorter cycles, feedback, collaboration, and adjustment as more is learned.

SIMPLY PUT Do some. Learn some. Adjust. Keep moving.

29

Hybrid

Using different project approaches together when different parts of the work need different ways of being managed.

SIMPLY PUT Some work needs room to adapt. Other work needs more predictability. Wisdom is knowing which is which — and bringing them together.

Take the Wisdom With You

30

Lessons Learned

Knowledge gained from what happened during the project that can improve future decisions and work.

SIMPLY PUT Don't leave the wisdom behind when the project ends.

BEFORE YOU GO

You Know More Than You Think

These words may be new. The experiences probably aren't.

You've dealt with limited time, plans changing, people you depended on not delivering when expected, costs that were higher than planned, and another “little thing” being added to something you were already trying to finish. You've probably solved a problem only to watch it return.

That's project management showing up in everyday life. The vocabulary simply gives you a way to recognize what's happening.

When something changes, look before reacting. When something keeps going wrong, look for the cause. When more work appears, determine whether it really belongs. When the numbers change, understand why. When people disagree, listen for what each person actually needs.

And if you're headed in the wrong direction, going faster won't solve the problem.

Check the direction before you press the gas — and when you see the road sign, be ready to pivot.

EXPERIENCE THE WORDS

Living Life as a Project Manager

You don't have to study this guide before moving forward. In this experience — a day in the life of a project manager — you'll meet many of these concepts without being told their names first. You'll face the situation, make the decision, and see what happens. Then you'll discover the project-management term behind the experience.

wisergenerations.com/liap/game

Because knowing the word is useful. Knowing what to do when it shows up in your life is wisdom.

CONTINUE THE JOURNEY

Words to Know is your introduction.

The bend is not the end. Be ready to make the turn.



THE BOOK · PUBLISHES NOVEMBER 30, 2026

Living Is a Project...Are You Ready?™

As you move forward, these words will begin to mean more because you'll see them in action — not simply on a page.

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SCAN TO PRE-BUY

ASSESS

Life Project-Ready™ Assessment

8 dimensions, 40 questions. See where you are and what deserves attention next. Free with pre-buy.

WORK

Be Ready to Make the Turn Workshop

A live 90-minute experience. Know your position. Make your next move. $49.

BUILD

Weekend Masterclass Retreat

Step away from the noise and build the road ahead. Join the interest list.

Visit Crystal's author page: wisergenerations.com/author
You're on the list for **the Living Is a Project Letter** every Tuesday and **Weekly Tips** every Saturday — a little structure, every week.

Life is a journey. *Enjoy the ride.*

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